It would be a long while, of course, before these newly minted mansabdars – and particularly the higher-ranking noblemen, ‘amirs’, among them – came to accept Akbar’s new design. Resentments would fester, battles would erupt – the turmoil would be such that even Muhammad Hakim, Akbar’s half-brother, safely retreated to Kabul these past many years, would sniff another opportunity in Hindustan.

If Akbar anticipated any of this in 1575, when he announced his reforms, he did not let it worry him unduly. In fact, having decided to bring his nobility to heel and their revenue into his own treasury, Akbar opened up a second front, too – he would also take on his clergy.

If the shahinshah was the symbolic core of the Mughal bureaucracy as it was now emerging, Akbar also occupied the literal centre of his Ibadat Khana. The building does not stand any longer, but the descriptions are clear. It was a large hall with four wings, each assigned to a particular group of men: amirs, philosophers, sayyids and Sufis. Akbar’s own seat was at the very centre of the hall, from where he watched them all, and ‘tested them company by company’[3] – until he formulated his own creed.

It was also at this time that the man whom you might call Akbar’s high priest re-entered his life. At his first shy meeting with the emperor, Abul Fazl had been invited to travel east with him. The young man had made his excuses. For all his claims about being invaded by love for the shahinshah, the reclusive scholar may have been quietly horrified at the idea of travelling so far away from home with a boisterous military camp. Abul Fazl had hurried back to his father’s house, while Akbar ‘gave rein to his river-drinking crocodile’[4] and sailed away to Patna.

Afterwards, Abul Fazl may have regretted not accepting the emperor’s invitation; or perhaps it was his family that was dismayed by such a wilfully missed opportunity. At any rate, he was back at court: armed with excuses (he couldn’t have travelled without his father’s permission); flattery (he’d had visions of Akbar’s victory); and yet another essay on yet another set of verses from the Quran (of which Badauni observes cattily, ‘people said it was written by his father’).

Walking through the grand mosque in Fatehpur, Abul Fazl saw the emperor arrive, in the distance. Not daring to approach, he bowed from where he stood. And . . . could it be? Akbar saw him, recognized him!